Base Reality Is Probably Boring

Elon Musk Brings Simulation Theory to Joe Rogan

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Nov 12, 2026

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In September 2018, Elon Musk sat down with Joe Rogan for two and a half hours (full episode). Most people remember the episode for a single moment near the end, when Rogan handed Musk a blunt and Musk took a puff (2:09:59). The clip ran on the news, and Tesla's stock dipped the next day.

Fewer people remember that about forty minutes in, the two men spent ten minutes discussing whether the studio they were sitting in was real. Nobody treated that part as news. That is the reason to start here.

In 1928 the sociologist W. I. Thomas wrote what became known as the Thomas theorem: that if people define situations as real, they are real in their consequences. Simulation theory invites the mirror image: if people define reality as possibly unreal, that definition has consequences too, whether or not it is true. The Rogan–Musk conversation is a clean specimen of the idea leaving the philosophy seminar and arriving at the kitchen table, delivered by the most famous engineer in the world to one of the largest audiences in media.

From Instagram to the simulation

The conversation doesn't begin with metaphysics. It begins with social media. Rogan has been talking about how Instagram lets people project "this sort of distorted version of who you really are," and he worries about what comes next (42:03):

> "Is it going to be augmented to some sort of a weird augmented or virtual sort of Instagram type situation where you're not going to want to live in this real world…"

Musk's answer is four words (42:25): "Go live in the simulation."

Rogan mentions that his kids love their VR headset and that it "kind of freaks me out." Musk's prediction for where that headset is going (43:21): "It will be, at some point, indistinguishable from reality."

Rogan reaches for something solid (43:27): "We'll lose this. Like you and I are just looking at each other through our eyes." Musk answers, "Are we?" — and then (43:36): "This could be some simulation."

The order matters. The path to the simulation runs through a complaint about curated selfies. The worry about a fake self online and the possibility of a fake world turn out to be one conversation.

The argument in thirty-five seconds

Rogan asks whether Musk really entertains the idea. Musk gives the whole case in about thirty-five seconds (43:42):

> "Well, the argument for the simulation, I think, is quite strong because if you assume any improvements at all over time, any improvement, 1%, 0.1%, just extend the time frame, make it a thousand years, a million years. The universe is 13.8 billion years old. Civilization… is maybe 7000 or 8000 years old… This is nothing."

And the conclusion (44:17):

> "So, if you assume any rate of improvement at all, then games will be indistinguishable from reality, or civilization will end. One of those two things will occur. Therefore, we are most likely in a simulation."

Three things are worth noticing about this as a piece of cultural transmission.

First, the argument arrives without its author. It is a compressed version of Oxford philosopher Nick Bostrom's 2003 paper "Are You Living in a Computer Simulation?", but Bostrom's name never comes up. By 2018 the idea had become common property, something one could simply say.

Second, the compression changes the logic. Bostrom's original is a three-way choice: civilizations die out before they can run such simulations, *or* they could but choose not to, *or* we are almost certainly simulated. Musk drops the middle option — that a civilization able to build a perfect simulation might have no interest in running one. With only two horns left, and "civilization will end" being the gloomier one, the simulation becomes the hopeful conclusion.

Third, Rogan pushes back, and his objection is a good one (44:42): "Or we're on our way to one, right?" Indistinguishable games may be coming, but that doesn't mean they're already here. Musk concedes at once (44:50): "It could be in base reality." And then he falls back on the plainest answer there is, the same one the English writer Samuel Johnson gave in 1763 when told the material world might be only an idea: he kicked a large stone. Musk's version (45:24): "This is real. You want to touch that wood? It feel very real."

Mason jars

What happens next is my favorite stretch of the episode, because Rogan turns from metaphysics to sociology. He has noticed something about how people live (45:29):

> "Maybe that's why everybody is like into like mason jars and shit… People that like craft restaurants, and they want raw wood… It seems like people are like longing toward some weird log cabin type nostalgia."

Musk supplies the missing word (45:44): "Sure, reality." And Rogan finishes the picture (45:48): people "dragging their nails" and saying, "Don't take me yet."

This is the claim at the heart of our topic, made by a comedian. Rogan is saying that the *suspicion* of unreality is already shaping taste — that reclaimed wood and Edison bulbs are a culture holding onto the handrail.

Musk then adds a twist (45:53): you can now buy a mason jar manufactured with a wine stem or a handle already attached. The emblem of homemade authenticity, mass-produced. The longing for the real is itself turned into a product. Those who remember the essay "The Comfortable Prison: The Matrix and the Philosophers" will recognize Baudrillard here — the copy that no longer has an original — but you don't need the theory to see it. You only need to have been in a Crate & Barrel.

The boring substrate

A few minutes later Rogan asks about the multiverse, and Musk folds it into the simulation (49:08): "There are many, many simulations. These simulations, we might as well call them reality, or we could call them

the multiverse." They run, he says, "on the substrate" — the real machinery underneath, whatever world the computer itself sits in. Then the line that gives this piece its title (49:27): "That substrate is probably boring."

His reasoning comes from the film set (50:10):

> "So, I think, most likely, if we're a simulation, it's really boring outside the simulation because why would you make simulation as boring? You'd make simulation way more interesting than base reality."

This is a value judgment dressed as a probability estimate, and it reverses the moral of *The Matrix*. In the film, the real world is a ruined and frightening place, but Neo chooses it anyway, because it is real; it is Cypher, the traitor, who trades it for the taste of a simulated steak. Musk's picture leaves out the horror and keeps only the tedium. Reality is the green screen. The simulation is the edited cut.

If people come to believe that, the case for preferring the real gets harder to make. It is no longer truth against comfort. It is truth against entertainment, and entertainment is the better-funded side.

"Where are you really?"

In the last turn of the conversation, Musk returns to the virtual-reality headset that Rogan's kids love, and asks where you are when you put it on (51:26):

> "When you're in that virtual reality, which is only going to get better, where are you? Where are you really?… You aren't anywhere. You're in the computer."

And then Musk turns it on Rogan himself (52:02): "Right now, you think you're in a studio in LA… You might be in a computer."

Rogan's reply is the most revealing sentence in the segment (52:05): "Man, I think about this all the time."

That is the cultural fact. The host of the most popular podcast in America doesn't treat the idea as exotic. It is already a regular resident of his mind, and he speaks for an audience in the millions who heard him say so.

The frame around it

The simulation talk doesn't appear out of nowhere. It sits inside an hour in which Musk describes human beings as a passing stage:

- We are "the biological bootloader for AI" (17:18) — the small program whose only job is to start the big one.
- Social networks are "giant cybernetic collectives," with all of us plugged in "as like nodes on the network" (15:38), and their success is measured in "limbic resonance" (18:53) — how strongly they play on the brain's emotional centers.
- "You're already a cyborg" (28:55); someday "you will be essentially snapshotted into a computer" (30:12). Rogan calls for the whiskey, and Musk says, "Down the rabbit hole" (30:27).
- On AI, his attitude has become "fatalistic" (13:16): "one thing is for sure, we will not control it" (24:04).

> **"Down the rabbit hole."** The phrase comes from Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865), where Alice follows a white rabbit down a hole into a world where the usual rules no longer hold. *The Matrix* borrows it directly: Neo is told to "follow the white rabbit," and Morpheus offers to show him "how deep the rabbit hole goes." When Musk reaches for the phrase, he is using the film's own words for leaving ordinary reality behind. (More on the Alice references in *The Matrix*.)

Put together, these make a single worldview: the self is already partly digital, the network is already a collective mind, control is already slipping away, and the world itself may be software. The simulation hypothesis is the capstone of that structure, not a stray joke.

And note who is saying it. Early in the episode Rogan floats the theory that Musk might be some "AI creature that's superior to people" sent to "fix a bunch of shit," and Musk plays along: "Because I'm an alien" (11:20). Since this interview, Musk has become the world's first trillionaire, at least on paper, and has reshaped industry (SpaceX, Tesla, the Starlink satellite network and its military counterpart, Starshield), media (he bought Twitter and renamed it X) and government (heavy spending in the 2024 election, then leading DOGE, the federal cost-cutting effort, in 2025). When a man with that kind of reach tells you reality may be a product, the claim carries an authority that the same words from a philosophy professor would not.

What the belief does

Here is where Thomas's point comes back. Whether or not we are simulated, the belief can push in different directions:

- **It can make the given world look second-rate.** If base reality is the boring substrate and the simulation is the good cut, the real becomes the thing you escape from, not the thing you defend.
- **It can feed fatalism.** If the game was written elsewhere, why struggle? This sits easily beside Musk's stated fatalism about AI.
- **It can also do the opposite.** Musk himself doesn't draw the passive conclusion. When Rogan wonders aloud why we are here, Musk says, "Let's find out," and then (53:06): "I think we should take the actions, the set of actions that are most likely to make the future better." The belief that the world might be unreal does not stop him from acting as if it is very real indeed.

That tension — a man who says reality is probably a simulation and also spends every waking hour trying to change it — is a good place for our discussion to start.

Questions for discussion

1. Rogan pushes back once ("we're on our way to [a simulation]") and Musk concedes immediately. Why do you think the concession didn't stick — in the conversation or in the culture?
2. Rogan reads mason jars and raw wood as people "clinging" to reality. Do you see that longing in your own life or your children's and grandchildren's? Is the craft-and-vintage world a resistance to the virtual, or just another product of it?
3. In *The Matrix*, the real world is harsh but worth choosing. In Musk's telling, it is merely boring. Which picture is more dangerous to believe?
4. Does believing we might be in a simulation make a person more passive, or less? What would Dostoevsky's Underground Man say to Musk?